

BLUE SHEEP FILMS
NOT ANOTHER WORD — Reader's Report

CONCEPT: A celebrated gonzo journalist, hollowed out by his own myth, tells an on-camera interviewer that the world would be better served by his death — and the people sitting opposite agree, because they have come to arrange it. He is not murdered. He is retired: his death staged, his obituary pre-printed, his unfinished work collected and scheduled for release by an institution that considers itself a benefactor.

SYNOPSIS: A female figure sets a crystal glass on a liquor cabinet and leaves.

MILES GOODMAN (late 30s) wakes at three in the afternoon in a small New York apartment described as a perfectly kept den of chaos. The ritual is exact and it is the film's structure: Chivas before the kettle boils, a cigarette selected from a wooden box of lighters, cocaine from a carved Yunnan dragon he was gifted on a mountain twenty years ago, the radio news, coffee cut with whiskey on the balcony while he watches the street. He showers with the mug on the counter. He calls his agent MCGARR and monologues about a game he invented with a local sheriff — one man pitching golf balls, the other shooting them out of the air — and is so far gone that he doesn't notice McGarr has hung up. He rides a red Vespa to Asters Pub, eats a day's worth of food alone in the corner booth, and returns to a locked study where he takes acid, loops vintage pornography he doesn't watch, and writes until a red cardinal lands on the windowsill at dawn. Two Halcyon. Sleep.

Day one is the ritual intact. On the television above the bar he watches himself being made the joke on a talk show and doesn't mind. A boy is sent over by his father for an autograph; Miles asks whether the father put him up to it, gets an honest yes, and tells the boy to keep that going — *"it will get you about half way there most of the time."* On the way out he is shoved through the front door of Asters by a biker and lands on his back in the glass.

Day two the ritual holds and the work does not. Blank pages stack beside scrapped ones. A weathered Indonesian book on the shelf takes him back to a lagoon off Lombok, a photograph of himself with two men and an enormous fish — *"Waste of film and a waste of fish."* He calls McGarr and gets voicemail, and quits everything: the book, the Paramount deal, the next project. He is retreating to Aspen. He mentions, almost in passing, that *those androids* are coming to interview him tomorrow. At the window, the cardinal does not sing.

Day three the world has rearranged itself. SHARI, the cleaner, empties his ashtray, sees an unmarked white van across the street marked "Drain Disposal," and goes straight to the telephone. Miles wakes to find his bandage changed by hands that are not his. Every apartment opposite has its curtains drawn. At Asters his booth is occupied, half the room is empty, and JOANSY will not seat him and cannot say why — *"We're not supposed to be expecting you."* Her parting line about those *who had the time* sends him to check his watch twice.

At home he waits, glancing between the clock and his wrist. The crew arrives: STACEY BRADSHAW and two men both introduced as Michael. They convert the living room into a television set while Miles, unprompted, explains why he distrusts cameras — *"the technology warps reality, it's a betrayal."*

The interview is the best conversation he has had in months, and he walks into the trap unassisted. Asked whether his lifestyle has cost him anything, he says that for there to be a lapse in his writing there would have to be a lapse in him. Asked what is next, he describes being consumed by his own reputation: he can no longer stand at the back and absorb a story because he appears inside it; his collected works are out in the fall and he is in the way as a person. *"It would be much better if I died, so people could take the myth. I have no choice... I have to kill off one life and start with another one."*

Stacey asks whether he would be happier dead. When he tries to break, she produces a rolled newspaper and directs him to page three: his own obituary, beside the Lombok photograph, complete through his

first journalism job, his travel writing, his first successful fiction and the woman he loved. *"It's tomorrow's paper."* The Michaels flank him. One takes his pulse with a stethoscope; the other presses him into the chair; a syringe goes into his neck.

The script then offers two endings and does not choose between them.

Ending 1 stays outside at sunrise. The Michaels wheel a gurney with a body bag to a van, exchanging shop talk about whether everything was collected and about somebody else's botched job. The sliding door closes and reveals the logo: *Sidman's Retirement Facility*.

Ending 2 follows him in. Miles wakes in a grey welcome room facing a projector. A recorded voice congratulates him on his arrival at Sidman's, an exclusive facility that collects important voices who have lost their tune, stages their deaths, and administers their legacies — elevating the work to heights unreachable without a sudden and untimely death. On screen, a news anchor stands outside his apartment reporting him found dead of an apparent overdose. Then the door opens behind him. *"Hi Miles. It's good to have you with us. I'm Doctor Lance Sidman. Welcome to retirement."*

ANALYSIS: This is a genuinely arresting piece of writing with one of the better central ironies in the bin, and it is not yet a finished script. The core conceit is excellent and it is excellent for a specific structural reason: the protagonist builds his own trap out loud, on camera, of his own free will. Miles argues that the myth would be better served by his death; an institution has been listening, agrees on the merits, and has already printed the obituary. Nobody has to be a villain for the film to be terrifying. Stacey never raises her voice and the recorded welcome message is warm throughout. That restraint is the script's best instinct and it should be protected in every subsequent draft.

The ritual structure is the second real achievement. Playing the same day three times, in the same order, with the same objects — the crystal glass, the wooden box of lighters, the dragon, the cardinal, the corner booth — turns the audience into someone who knows this apartment as well as Miles does, which means the film can do its work by subtraction. Day three is frightening almost entirely because of things that are *missing*: the cardinal that doesn't sing, the curtains that are drawn, the booth that is taken, the bandage that has already been changed. That is confident, cinematic construction, and it is achieved without a line of exposition. The apartment is also, from a production standpoint, a gift — one principal location, two brief flashbacks, a pub, and a grey room.

Shari is the script's quietest and cleverest device, and she is currently under-resolved. She opens the film, she is present in the negative space of every day, and she is the only character who notices the van and acts on it. But what she does with that phone call is never established, and it matters enormously: if she is warning Miles, the film contains an attempted rescue that fails and nobody ever learns about; if she is reporting to Sidman's, the person closest to him has been an instrument the whole time and the first image of the film is a betrayal. Either reading is strong. The script should commit, and the commitment costs almost nothing on the page.

The central problem is the ending, and it is not a small one. **Two endings are written and neither is chosen.** They are not variants of the same beat — they are different films. Ending 1 is cold, external and withholding: a body bag, two contractors talking logistics, a logo on a van door. It trusts the audience entirely and leaves Miles as an object, which is thematically ruthless. Ending 2 goes inside, explains the entire operation in a corporate voiceover, and finishes on a handshake and a punchline. It is more satisfying and considerably less frightening, and the explanation it delivers — including the reveal that the operation has done this before, badly, to someone named Millar — answers questions the film is stronger for leaving open. A reader cannot assess the film's final shape while both are on the page, and any financier or director will ask the same question first. Choosing is the single most valuable decision available. For what it is worth, Ending 1 is the better film and Ending 2 contains one image worth

rescuing into it: the news broadcast reporting his death, which could play under the van's departure without a word of explanation.

Two further notes. First, the source. The script is credited as based on the life of Hunter S. Thompson and it does not distance itself much: the Chivas, the ESPN column, shotgun golf with the sheriff, the Zippo inscription, the collected works volume, the celebrity that swallowed the reporting — these are specifics, not resemblances, and the film's premise is a counter-factual about the manner of a real person's death. The protagonist has been renamed and the events are invented, which is the right instinct, but this needs a clearance conversation before a production draft rather than after one. It is answerable — the question is whether the film is a fiction inhabiting a real life or a biography with the names changed, and the script should decide deliberately rather than by default.

Second, the draft is early in a way that will affect how it is received. There are copy errors throughout — *writting, shinning, privledged, Chigaco, your not, half had gallon* — and a handful of scenes where the writing gestures rather than stages, particularly the Yunnan flashback, which currently summarises a night of festivities in three sentences. There is also a persistent structural tic worth watching: several scenes end on Miles alone with an object, which is beautiful the first four times and begins to feel like a default by the twentieth. None of this is hard to fix and none of it is a reason to hesitate, but a clean pass before the script goes out will materially change the first impression.

The dialogue is the pleasant surprise. Miles is funny without the script straining, his monologues have the right runaway quality, and the exchange with Joansy — where a woman has to turn away a regular for reasons she has been told not to give — is the best-written scene in the piece. Stacey's turn from interviewer to operator is achieved almost entirely through posture and one sentence of stage direction. The child at the booth is the film's only moment of uncomplicated grace and it earns its place.

TARGET AUDIENCE: Adults 25–54, skewing male. Festival programming, with a natural life as a proof-of-concept for a feature — the Sidman's premise is plainly larger than this script uses, and the institution is the part an audience will want more of.

READER'S RECOMMENDATION: Recommended, with reservations

A distinctive, confident and genuinely unsettling piece built on a premise that pays for itself: a man talks himself into his own disappearance and the people listening simply agree. The ritual structure is expertly built and the restraint in the final act is exactly right. Three things stand between this and a production draft, and all three are decisions rather than repairs — choose one ending, settle what Shari's phone call means, and resolve the Hunter S. Thompson question deliberately. A copy pass would also change the first impression considerably. The material underneath is strong enough to justify all of it.

Screenplay, 32 pages, 47 scenes — approx. 30 min. Written by Sacha Mitchell and Cairns Nolan, based on the life of Hunter S. Thompson. Drama. Contemporary-period New York, one principal apartment. Draft dated June 2026. Internal development pass, 28 July 2026.